



AVs and cities

A study on how autonomy and electrification can result in increased urban sprawls and congestion on roads. <https://digit.in/oct19-59>



Social problems

This study explores the social and ethical consequences of the algorithms that will drive autonomous cars <https://digit.in/oct19-60>



THE FUTURE OF AUTONOMOUS CARS

While self driving cars sound exciting, the advantages are not as clear as they first appear.

Aditya Madanapalle | aditya@digit.in

ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS

The ethics of self driving cars can be summed up by the trolley problem. In the classic version of the problem, there is a trolley barreling down the tracks, and the driver has to make a choice between staying on the tracks and switching them. If he stays on the tracks, then five people get killed. However, if he switches them, then a single person gets killed. In 2014,

researchers from MIT set up a “Moral Machine” to test the attitudes and approaches of people around the world, to some tricky problems that would arise for autonomous vehicles. Essentially, the vehicle had to make a choice of what to crash into. For example, the car is going to collide with a pet, should it swerve to instead collide with a human? Such situations were set up for disabled, old, young, law abiding citizens, criminals, men, women, fit and sickly people. Edmond Awad, the lead author of the study

explains, “the study is basically trying to understand the kinds of moral decisions that driverless cars might have to resort to. We don’t know yet how they should do that.” The vehicle would have to be very smart to find out who is fit, and a privacy hazard, if it can identify criminals, but let’s just assume that the vehicle can make such a distinction. After four years, the researchers had their answer. The decisions programmed into self-driving cars may have to depend on where in the world the car is located. For